Confluence CQL cheat sheet: queries you can copy

CQL is the query language behind Confluence search. Below are the queries people actually need, each one run against a live Confluence Cloud site before it went on this page, plus the few traps that quietly return the wrong pages.

Short answer. A CQL query is `field operator value`, joined with `AND`, `OR` and `NOT`, optionally followed by `ORDER BY`. Pages nobody touched in six months: `type = page AND lastmodified < now("-26w")`. Pages with two labels at once: `label = "policy" AND label = "hr"`, not `label IN (...)`, which means "any of". Your starred pages: `favourite = currentUser()`.

Where to run it

Atlassian documents CQL as part of the Confluence REST API (Advanced searching using CQL). The quickest way to try a query, with your own permissions, is to open this address in a browser where you are logged in to Confluence, with your query at the end:

```
https://your-site.atlassian.net/wiki/rest/api/content/search?cql=type = page AND space = DEV
```

The browser fills in the encoding. You get JSON: titles, IDs and links in `results`, the total in `totalSize`. Scripts and apps use the same endpoint, which is why a query that works here works there too.

The building blocks

Field	What it matches	Example
`type`	page, blogpost, comment, attachment, whiteboard, database, folder	`type IN (page, blogpost)`

Field	What it matches	Example
`space`	Space key	`space = DEV`
`title`	Title, exact or contains	`title ~ "policy"`
`text`	Words anywhere in the content	`text ~ "vacation policy"`
`label`	Labels	`label = "onboarding"`
`created` , `lastmodified`	Dates, with functions	`lastmodified < now("-180d")`
`creator` , `contributor`	Who created or edited	`contributor = currentUser()`
`favourite` , `watcher` , `mention`	Starred by, watched by, mentioning a user	`mention = currentUser()`
`parent` , `ancestor`	Direct children, whole tree below a page	`ancestor = 123456`
`macro`	Pages using a macro	`macro = "drawio"`
`pageStatus`	The status lozenge on a page	`pageStatus = "Verified"`

Operators: `=` , `!=` , `<` , `>` , `<=` , `>=` (dates), `IN` , `NOT IN` , and `~` , `!~` (contains, for title and text). Date functions: `now("-4w")` , `startOfDay()` , `startOfWeek("-1w")` , `startOfMonth()` , `startOfYear()` and their `endOf` pairs. User functions: `currentUser()` .

Queries for real tasks

Stale content

```
type = page AND lastmodified < now("-26w") ORDER BY lastmodified ASC
type = page AND space = DEV AND lastmodified < now("-180d")
```

```
type = page AND lastmodified < startOfYear()
type = page AND lastmodified < now("-180d") AND NOT label = "archived"
```

Oldest first is the useful order: the top of the list is where the forgotten pages are. More on what to do with them in [how to find the Confluence pages nobody maintains](#).

Labels

```
 label = "policy" AND label = "hr"          (both labels)
label IN ("policy", "hr")                  (either label)
type = page AND label NOT IN ("archived")
```

You and your colleagues

```
 favourite = currentUser()                  (your starred pages)
creator = currentUser() AND type = page    (pages you created)
contributor = currentUser() ORDER BY lastmodified DESC
mention = currentUser()                    (pages that @mention you)
watcher = currentUser()
```

For another person, use their account ID instead of `currentUser()`: names do not work in Confluence Cloud, which only matches users by account ID.

A section of the tree

```
 parent = 123456      (direct children only)
ancestor = 123456    (everything below, at any depth)
```

The number is the page ID, the digits in the page address after `/pages/`.

By content

```
 title ~ "policy" AND type = page
text ~ "vacation policy"
macro = "drawio"                 (pages with a draw.io diagram)
type = attachment AND title ~ "docx"
pageStatus = "Rough draft"
```

Recent activity

```
created >= startOfWeek("-1w") AND type = blogpost
type IN (page, blogpost) AND space IN (DEV, OPS) ORDER BY created DESC
```

Traps that return the wrong pages

- **`m` is minutes, `M` is months.** On our test site `lastmodified > now("-6m")` returned nothing and `now("-6M")` returned every page. Use `d` or `w` if you want to avoid the question.
- **A name returns nothing, without an error.** `creator = "Mikhail"` came back empty while `creator = currentUser()` found every page of the same person. In Confluence Cloud user fields take account IDs; a name is not rejected, it just matches no one.
- **A Forge app's macro is found only by its module key.** In the storage format a Forge macro carries a key like `<app-id>/<environment-id>/static/<module-key>`. On our test site, with one of our own Forge macros on nine pages, `macro = "<module-key>"` found all nine; the full key and the app ID returned zero, again without an error. Worth knowing before you conclude that nobody uses an app you are about to uninstall. The module key is chosen by the vendor, so two apps can share one; open a couple of hits.
- **`label IN` means any, not all.** We checked on two test pages, one with labels A and B, one with only A: `label IN ("A", "B")` returned both pages, `label = "A" AND label = "B"` returned one. Label case does not matter.
- **A query cannot start with a negative clause.** Atlassian's documentation says so: put `NOT label = "archived"` after a positive condition such as `type = page AND`.
- **Without parentheses, conditions are read left to right.** Mixing AND and OR without brackets gives surprising results; bracket every OR group.
- **Not every field can be sorted.** Ordering by a field a page can have several values of, labels for example, is not supported.
- **Brand new pages show up a little later.** In our test a page created a minute earlier did not appear yet; after about a minute it did. Search runs on an index.
- **Results are capped when you ask for page bodies.** Atlassian notes that with `expand=body.storage.value` the endpoint returns at most 50 results, whatever limit you ask for.

The arithmetic

Writing a query takes a minute once you know the fields. The cost is elsewhere: CQL results live in a JSON response or a script, not on a page your colleagues read. A monthly "pages not updated in six months" list for five teams means someone runs five queries, turns JSON into something readable and posts it, every month. That is roughly an hour a month for one person, and it stops the month that person is busy.

If you only need an answer for yourself once, the browser address above is free and enough.

When the list should live on a page

Disclosure: I build Smart Search for Confluence. It builds the CQL for you from simple settings (space, labels, words, "not updated for N days") and shows the result as a live list on a Confluence page, so readers see it without running anything. Several labels mean all of them, as most people expect. It runs inside Atlassian's infrastructure and is free for teams up to ten people.

Frequently asked

How do I find pages not updated in 6 months?

`type = page AND lastmodified < now("-26w") ORDER BY lastmodified ASC` . Offsets like `-180d` or `-6M` work too; lowercase `-6m` is six minutes.

How do I find pages with two labels at once?

One condition per label, joined with AND. `label IN` returns pages with any of them.

How do I list my starred pages?

`favourite = currentUser()` . It only ever shows your own starred pages, never someone else's.

What is the difference between ancestor and parent?

`parent` gives direct children, `ancestor` the whole tree below a page.

How do I find pages that use a Forge app's macro?

`macro = "module-key"`, where the module key is the part after `static/` in the macro's extension key in the page storage format. The full key and the app ID return nothing.

Can I search by a person's name?

Not in Confluence Cloud: user fields take account IDs. `currentUser()` covers the common case of searching for yourself.

Related: how to list Confluence pages on a page without writing CQL, finding pages nobody maintains, and what to use now that CQL Search is ending. Also: how to see your starred pages. Also: finding pages that use a macro, and when CQL misses them.

Source and updates: https://horizonventures.app/docs/confluence-cql-cheat-sheet.html. Horizon Ventures E.I.R.L.